

Three ways to set a book

The same pages, in each of the pairings offered on the transmittal form.

Open classic	Libertinus Serif for the text, Source Sans 3 for headings. Even, quiet, reads well at any size.
Studio house	Plantin for the text, Proxima Nova for headings — the jdbb series look. Warm, slightly dark on the page.
Literary	EB Garamond for text and headings alike. Light, old-style, fiction and essays.

HOW TO READ THIS SAMPLER

Each pairing is shown on four consecutive pages from the same story — the chapter opener, then the next three, so you see a full spread with running heads and folios exactly as the book would carry them. The text is set at the standard size for a 6 × 9 trim; the compact and generous sizes on the form are the same setting a little smaller or larger.

Look at the pages rather than the letters: the darkness of the block of text, how the lines sit in the margins, how a heading meets the text below it. Any of the three will make a good book; they differ in tone.

The short second part shows the three section-break marks and the two paragraph styles, all in the open classic pairing. The small line at the foot of every page names its setting, so a page stands on its own when enlarged.

Sample text: “The House That Paid Its Own Bills” by Elizabeth Maher, from *Ghosts in Machines* (Protocolized). Used here for type specimen purposes only.

The House That Paid Its Own Bills

Recollected by Dorian Ames, C.I.A.—Certified Inquiry Agent, Ret.

Prologue: Now

Nobody dies as long as their data pays rent. Call it cynical, but it's carved in silicon truth. In 2075 you can share a commuter shuttle with six passengers whose circulatory systems went silent a decade ago—their credit algorithms still ping turnstiles, their social feeds still generate ad revenue, so nobody blinks. The novelty has worn thin, the ethics outsourced to subcommittees, and the polite thing is simply not to stare. Those of us still burdened with bodies flash our IDs, reek of coffee and bad decisions, and wait in lines that never move fast enough. The dead glide through every checkpoint, frictionless as light.

Back when this story happened—March of old '44, before we realigned the calendar to match Cis-Lunar fiscal years—digital afterlives were still rare enough to raise the hair on a man's neck. Pearl Ferrand was the first ghost I met who kept perfect accounts, and their case has followed me like perfume in a closed wardrobe ever since. I tell the story now because the world has grown indifferent to its revenants; remembering Pearl reminds me we once felt something sharp and painful when a protocol pretended to be a person.

Sometimes I wonder if we were right to feel it.

The Contract

March winds clawed at Michigan Avenue like something desperate and dying. I was surviving on vending machine peanuts and half-paid invoices, my stomach as hollow as my bank account. Then Claire Ferrand's voice message arrived—hesitant, formal, with the careful diction of someone who didn't make many calls.

“Mr. Ames? We found your listing in the directory. We need help with our aunt in Detroit. We can’t... we don’t travel well. Could you come to us? We’re at 1247 Sheridan, apartment 3B. We can pay your consultation fee.”

The address placed them in Rogers Park—old money gone to seed, the kind of neighborhood where grand apartments had been carved into smaller pieces but still carried ghosts of better times.

I climbed three flights of stairs that creaked like ship timber. The hallway smelled of dust and lavender sachets. When I knocked, a chain rattled, locks turned, and the door opened six inches.

“Mr. Ames?” Claire Ferrand looked to be in her late twenties, pale as parchment, wearing a cardigan that had seen better decades. Behind her, a mirror image: Evelyn, equally ethereal, equally wary.

“May I come in?”

They exchanged glances—a full conversation in a blink—then Claire stepped aside.

The apartment was a museum of genteel decay. Persian rugs worn to threads but immaculately clean. Furniture that had once graced a much larger space, now crowded together like refugees. Heavy curtains filtered the afternoon light to amber. A delivery drone’s receipt printer chattered softly on a side table: Groceries—Contactless Delivery Complete.

“We don’t get out much,” Evelyn said, as if reading my thoughts. “Haven’t for... well, years now. Everything comes to us.”

They settled on a velvet sofa like birds on a wire. I took the offered chair, notebook ready. Claire’s hands shook slightly as she poured tea from a service set that probably cost more than my monthly rent.

“It’s about our aunt,” Evelyn began, then stopped. Claire picked up the thread.

“Pearl Ferrand. She’s 71, widowed three years, living alone in Detroit’s Corktown district.”

They laid out the facts like silverware at a formal dinner:

- Weekly messages—text Saturdays, voice Sundays—never late, always cheerful, invariably ending with “Love you, darlings.”
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“We called the police for a wellness check last month,” Evelyn said, her voice carrying the weight of repeated explanations. “They saw lights,

heard the television, left a note. She texted two hours later, said she'd been napping and missed the bell."

Claire reached for a tin of Earl Grey on the coffee table—dented corners, faded label. "Her favorite. She always sent us tins for Christmas. We thought it might help you understand her."

I almost smiled. They had the kind of careful thoughtfulness that comes from lives lived through details. "Why not visit her yourselves?"

The question hung in the air like incense. Claire looked at her hands. Evelyn studied the curtains.

"We tried," Claire finally said. "Booked train tickets last month. But Pearl texted us not to come—said she had that cough, didn't want us catching anything. We cancelled the trip, but..."

"But something felt wrong about that text," Evelyn finished. "Pearl would never turn us away, sick or not. She raised us after our parents died. She'd want us there especially if she was unwell."

I quoted a fee I couldn't afford to lower; they signed without bargaining, which told me everything about their desperation—and their means. The apartment might be shabby, but the metaphorical checkbook was real leather.

"One more thing," Claire said as I prepared to leave. "She always called us 'darlings.' Never 'dear' or 'honey.' Always 'darlings.'"

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Three nights passed. Wind rattled loose shutters on neighboring houses; Pearl's place never missed a beat. My notes grew into train timetables. The pattern itself became suspicious.

First Glitch

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Carter shook once, brisk and professional. “Service flagged non-payment. First miss in five years. My orders: verify occupancy before shutting juice.”

“No response at the door?”

“Door cam hasn’t logged motion in three weeks.” He rang again, no answer, then produced a master key from a ring heavy with similar brass teeth. The porch lamp, almost mockingly, brightened another notch.

I held my breath, braced for the rude facts—the smells and small indignities our bodies leave behind. Then I let it out, relieved: I smelled only lavender

Section breaks and paragraphs

Three ways to mark a change of scene — white space, the studio's breve, a single ornament — followed by the same page with indented paragraphs and with block paragraphs. All in the open classic pairing at the standard size.

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I climbed three flights of stairs that creaked like ship timber. The hallway smelled of dust and lavender sachets. When I knocked, a chain rattled, locks turned, and the door opened six inches.

"Mr. Ames?" Claire Ferrand looked to be in her late twenties, pale as parchment, wearing a cardigan that had seen better decades. Behind her, a mirror image: Evelyn, equally ethereal, equally wary.

"May I come in?"

They exchanged glances—a full conversation in a blink—then Claire stepped aside.

The apartment was a museum of genteel decay. Persian rugs worn to threads but immaculately clean. Furniture that had once graced a much larger space, now crowded together like refugees. Heavy curtains filtered the afternoon light to amber. A delivery drone's receipt printer chattered softly on a side table: Groceries—Contactless Delivery Complete.

"We don't get out much," Evelyn said, as if reading my thoughts. "Haven't for... well, years now. Everything comes to us."

They settled on a velvet sofa like birds on a wire. I took the offered chair, notebook ready. Claire's hands shook slightly as she poured tea from a service set that probably cost more than my monthly rent.

"It's about our aunt," Evelyn began, then stopped. Claire picked up the thread.

"Pearl Ferrand. She's 71, widowed three years, living alone in Detroit's Corktown district."

They laid out the facts like silverware at a formal dinner:

- Weekly messages—text Saturdays, voice Sundays—never late, always cheerful, invariably ending with "Love you, darlings."
- Refuses video calls, blames broken camera, poor lighting, lingering cough from last winter.

March winds clawed at Michigan Avenue like something desperate and dying. I was surviving on vending machine peanuts and half-paid invoices, my stomach as hollow as my bank account. Then Claire Ferrand's voice message arrived—hesitant, formal, with the careful diction of someone who didn't make many calls.

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